to make it to the White House at a time of international tension—and Defense Secretary Flournoy find themselves called on to support a new Filipino government in its attempts to counter China's annexation of the Scarborough Shoal, things rapidly escalate from midair and surface collisions to the biggest naval clashes since World War II.

Although both sides pull back from the brink of committing ground forces or firing nuclear missiles, the net result of the conflict is a decisive shift in the balance of regional power to the advantage of China.

The key point of this hypothetical exercise is that, although American air power is still superior to Chinese, the US Navy no longer has the relative strength to win such a war against its Chinese counterpart in a theater so far from the United States and so near to China. Nor, Auslin suggests, are the relationships with Taiwan, South Korea, or the Philippines strong enough for the United States to be able to count on them in a showdown with China. In his war scenario, all three defect from the US side to protect themselves.

Such future histories only rarely come to pass. But that is sometimes because they achieve their objective of making contemporary strategists think again. No one who reads this book will put it down content with the state of American strategy in the so-called Indo-Pacific region. They may even conclude that the very concept of an Indo-Pacific strategy is misconceived. If nothing else, they will be compelled by Auslin's argument that it is control of the "rimlands" that will determine which of the two superpowers wins the unfolding struggle for mastery in East Asia.

This admiring reader could only wonder how the United States could possibly cope with a coordinated challenge in all three of the key maritime theaters identified by Spykman. The great merit of this kind of historically informed writing about contemporary geopolitics is precisely that it raises such new and deeply troubling questions.

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